

The morning was born with a rare delicacy, the kind that seems intent on rebuilding the world from the first slit of light. The sky, still damp with blue, yielded to soft shades of rose drifting slowly across thin clouds; and the birds, awake before anyone else, stitched the silence with gentle songs, ushering in the day like an announcement of renewal. Through the half-open curtains, daylight slipped into the bedroom with the caution of something unwilling to disturb anything sacred — only to savor it. He woke first, contemplating her sleeping face beneath the faint glow of dawn, and leaned closer with the tenderness of someone who had finally understood the value of staying. The kiss placed upon her forehead was light, almost a breath, yet enough for her eyes to open slowly. She found him there, so near, with that same look she had known from their first meeting — a look whole, passionate, unguarded, recognizing and surrendering all at once. They remained that way for a moment no clock would dare measure, embraced as if the entire world could fit within that shared breath. The warmth of their bodies drew together with the natural ease of things that had never ceased to belong to one another; and, wrapped in the quiet of morning, they gave themselves to love without haste, as though sealing in silence a promise at last finding its home. Later, they rose together in a tacit agreement of continuity, letting the dawn complete what their gestures had begun — and went, side by side, into another day, as if life itself had just been newly inaugurated for them both. (1)

“Get up from this bed, my love.” (2)

“I love when you call me that.” (3)

“Looks like I danced just right between your hips.” (4)

“Of course, dear.” — The reply came promptly, drawing a smile. (5)

“Make sure you don’t forget.” (6)

“What!?” (7)

“I can’t believe you’re asking me that — it’s even on TV.” (8)

“The medical school graduation ball tonight.” (9)

The question came gently, almost as if afraid of spoiling the rare sweetness of that morning — whether they might have breakfast together, a small but habitual gesture, the kind that builds the quiet intimacy of a day. The answer came quickly, wrapped in haste and lateness: no, not today, they had overslept. The sound of that refusal left in him a small, almost childish disarray, which a discreet smile tried to conceal. Even so, his eyes followed her movements —

hurried, yet affectionate — and for a few brief seconds wished time could be held by the edge, just to prolong that simple moment which, suddenly, felt too important to lose. (10)

“Come on, help me zip up this dress.” (11)

“Yes, madam — with great pleasure, my love.” (12)

“I hate that sarcasm of yours.” (13)

Some time later, in the heart of another setting... (14)

“Good morning.” (15)

Good morning, my beloved daughter. Not a single word actually left; it remained buried within — thought stilled in its depths. (16)

“That’s polite, isn’t it?” (17)

“What was that?!” (18)

“I wished you good morning.” (19)

“Good morning, my beloved daughter. I’m exhausted from last night — forgive me.”
(20)

“My mother — where is she?” (21)

“Looks like she went back to sleep. And speaking of that, you went to bed early yesterday — what kind of miracle was that?” (22)

“I guess it was boredom!” (23)

“I’m worried. Your mother’s taking too long, could it be...” (24)

“There she is!” (25)

“I insist, dear, join us — let’s have breakfast together.” (26)

“I can’t. I’ll have breakfast at the hospital.” (27)

“You’d better eat before you go.” (28)

“I’m on my way out.” (29)

“Go on, you can go.” (30)

“A kiss. I won’t be long.” (31)

“Alright then, it’s settled.” (32)

“What’s going on with her?!” (33)

“Still not used to it? Should be by now.” (34)

“That’s true. You’re right.” (35)

Moments later, a vibration shattered the brief stretch of silence, insistent as if demanding an answer. The phone lit up on the surface, revealing only the word “Work” on the screen — an unexpected notice, out of place in the ordinary flow of things. There was a flicker of hesitation, the kind in which even breathing seems heavier than it should be, and the hand moving toward the device trembled with almost imperceptible doubt. The vibration persisted, pulsing like a reminder of something that could not be ignored. At last, a finger slid across the screen to answer. (36)

From the outside, anyone listening would have heard only a monologue — words cast into the air in reply to a voice that reached no one else’s ears. (37)

“Hello.” Three simple letters, still heavy with sleep as they left the vocal cords. (38)

“You are...” (39)

“Why?” (40)

“I think I’m more sober than ever!” (41)

“I’ve just received the coordinates.” (42)

“I understand perfectly. I’m always at your disposal, ma’am. You may call me at any hour — I’ll attend to you with great pleasure.” (43)

“Yes!” (44)

“Absolutely. I am fully conscious.” (45)

He ended the call, and a sudden tightness crossed his chest — brief yet sharp, as though something inside had shifted out of place. That call had not been expected, least of all on a Sunday, and the strangeness of the timing stirred a small, silent unrest in his thoughts. He remained still for a few seconds, the device still warm in his palm, trying to sort through what he felt, but nothing aligned at once: only a diffuse discomfort, an unease rising from somewhere deeper than reason could reach. (46)

“Strange, on a Sunday?” Thought aloud. (47)

“I’m heading out, my daughter. Behave yourself. I’ll be back soon — don’t go anywhere.” (48)

He grabbed the car keys quickly and left without saying anything more. (49)

In the parallel fragment of that same moment... (50)

In a slow gesture, still marked by the weight of the late night, a hand reached for the device beside the bed. The face carried that warm, rumpled softness — the gentle imprint of a night consumed in skin and breath; half-closed eyes held the lingering density left by passion that had filled every hour. The alarm was silenced, and the head tilted just enough to catch the time — and in the brief silence that followed, there seemed to be regret at the simple fact that the day had begun. A new cycle came the voiceless murmur. The motel sign, which hours earlier had pulsed sweet and complicit like a forbidden promise, now lay dark, neutralized by the raw light of dawn. Each ray slipping through the crack in the curtain did not illuminate: it exposed. Where pleasure had been, bitterness remained; where the night had seemed to conceal, the day revealed without mercy. (51)

“Last night was wonderful. I’ll promise you an even better one — just not today.” (52)

“Just once and you’d already be in love with me?” (53)

“You’d better hurry, or you’ll be late.” (54)

“You know... now that I think about it, I already am — a few extra minutes more or less won’t matter after such sweet memories. I’m a master at inventing excuses.” Spoken with a hint of self-satisfaction. (55)

“With all due respect, my sweet dear, if anyone sees us leaving this place, what will they think...” A faint sigh followed, as though the thought had slipped away on its own. (56)

“We always knew the risk of our situation.” (57)

“Do you think I want us identified?” (58)

“She knows!” (59)

“Who knows what?” (60)

“My wife. And I’m telling you — if she calls you and you’re not convincing enough to prove my innocence, the one who will find out is your spouse.” (61)

“Disgusting cretinism!” (62)

“I have no intention of arguing. I’m simply informing you that from now on, seek whoever you wish — just not me.” (63)

“What do you mean — to sleep with me?!” (64)

“I don’t want to be complicit in this.” (65)

“Complicit? You were the impure act itself. I see no complicity — only cowardice.” (66)

“You see? I’m never understood by you!” (67)

“There’s nothing left for us to talk about.” (68)

“You’re impossible — always ironic, always harsh. I don’t know what else to do.” (69)

“Oh! After indulging in every inch of someone else’s body, it’s easy to talk. Speak, hypocrite!” (70)

“You’re making a mountain out of a molehill.” (71)

“You speak like every guilty soul claiming innocence. Cowardice! Filth!” (72)

In a brief moment, there was an interruption — a knock at the door. (73)

“Good morning, ma’am?” (74)

“I’ll step out. I’ll leave you two alone.” (75)

“No need. You can stay.” (76)

“I think it’s better if I don’t. Excuse me.” (77)

“Your driver is waiting for you in the comfort of your luxury car’s air-conditioning. Don’t be late.” Spoken with irony. (78)

“How nice — I have a private driver at my disposal!” Exclaimed in the same mocking tone. (79)

“Goodbye, ingratitude. And yet I’m the only one who’s ironic!” (80)

The expression hardened, and the door was slammed shut. (81)

What she had just heard unsettled her stride — she nearly stumbled, as if legs and thoughts had collided at once. (82)

She hurried forward; yet the instant the staircase began beneath her feet, something extinguished the world around her — sound recoiled as though swallowed whole, light lost its substance — and the body gave way. Step after step, it tumbled down, as if torn from its own axis, rolling to the bottom in brutal silence. (83)

“Ma’am, can you hear me?” (84)

“What happened?” (85)

“You fell down the stairs.” (86)

“I don’t remember.” (87)

“That’s normal after fainting.” (88)

“How are you feeling?” (89)

“Fine, don’t worry. I’m alright. How long was I unconscious?” (90)

“You were unconscious for a few hours.” (91)

A disconsolate expression crossed her face in the middle of the exchange, and she said:
(92)

“I’m late!” Spoken in a lamenting tone, almost palpable, as if the entire night had been spent awake. (93)

“You’re not in any condition. I strongly recommend that you—” (94)

“I have to go!” (95)

“Are you sure you’re not feeling anything?” (96)

“I’m shaken. I didn’t sleep properly, that’s all!” Cut short, rising to her feet. (97)

In the space where vehicles rest before new journeys: (98)

“Are you alright, ma’am?” The question came again, edged with concern. (99)

“Yes, I’m fine.” (100)

“Forgive the interruption without notice.” (101)

“You’re only doing your job. I understand.” (102)

“I appreciate that. I’m glad.” (103)

“Thank you. I return the courtesy. I have no intention of dragging you into gossip — nor myself. That’s why you are exclusively mine. The best driver there is.” (104)

“It’s fine.” The reply came strained, almost caught in the throat. (105)

They got into the car and left the parking lot with a certain urgency, engines and headlights gliding as though the world were slightly out of focus. At the wheel, a disconcerting smile slipped free — the kind that seems to rise from a place where memory stumbles — and, in a strange lapse, almost vertigo, stillness took hold for a few seconds, as if that moment had already been lived, a *déjà vu* that asked no permission. A breath was drawn, and the dragging tone returned — nearly inert from the haze excitement had left in the voice — saying that the city always brought to mind his own, words sliding out of alignment with the present moment: “You are more beloved than my own wife.” She turned her face just enough to follow with her eyes, unsettled by the lack of sense, murmuring that attention should remain on the road; the reply came — still drifting in that slow unraveling of speech — that it must have been only the lapse, “things that appear without asking,” it continued, while the car moved forward, suspended between highways, thoughts, and everything that had yet to be spoken. (106)

“We’ve arrived.” Said in a tone tinged with melancholy and a certain unrest. (107)

“Bastard, what’s that supposed to mean — more beloved than your own wife?” Said with an ironic, uncomfortable edge. (108)

As if fleeing the answer, the door was opened quickly and, like a gentleman, the passenger side was reached and opened for her. (109)

“It was only an involuntary reaction to a strong emotional impact.” (110)

“Emotional impact? That’s what I had — it felt like the world was about to collapse in an instant!” (111)

“For that, I apologize.” (112)

“You should. You look like you’re drifting in the clouds, not paying attention.” (113)

“But I still have something to tell you—” (114)

“Do you want me to be late?! What could possibly be so important?!” Cut short. (115)

“I am requesting my resignation right now!” Spoken in a raised tone. (116)

“Watch how you speak to me. I am not your daughter! I am your boss!” (117)

“Have you lost your mind? What’s gotten into you—” (118)

“I have not!” Cut off abruptly. (119)

“What I mean is... how am I supposed to explain that I was working on a Sunday?”
(120)

“Here, take your payment. That way you can prove to your wife that you were working — before she kills you,” exclaimed with irony. “Daddy!” (121)

“I deserve it.” Spoken with a trace of self-contempt. (122)

“I have nothing more to discuss with you, ma’am. Good day.” (123)

“You did it! Consider the money I gave you your final salary. You’re fired! Bastard!”
(124)

“Great! Saint!” (125)

A glance at the clock display brought a jolt of reality — time had not waited; it had rushed forward, relentless and unbroken — not wound by batteries, nor subject to anyone’s will. A hurried departure followed, straight home. (126)

“I’m home!” Exclaimed with urgency. (127)

“Mom’s been at the hospital since early this morning.” (128)

“Damn! I’ll call her right now.” (129)

The phone was picked up, breath still warm from the previous exchange, the tone adjusted to sound awake, ordinary. When the call connected, the sound of the hospital came with it — hurried footsteps, distant voices, and scattered fragments cutting across the line: (130)

“Heart rate...” (131)

“Bring the defibrillator...” (132)

Phone ringing. (133)

“Clear the airway...” (134)

Agitated voices... (135)

“Move him to the OR...” (136)

The phone was moved slightly away to give a quick instruction, then brought back with breath still uneven, explaining it was only hospital routine and that the graduating students were helping with preparations for the celebration. A question followed — whether enough rest

had been had to accompany her that night — and the reply came, with the slight hesitation of someone improvising, that the boss had sent him on an unusual trip and the return had been late — the reason for sounding somewhat unsettled. A tired sigh followed, but without suspicion, saying that once finished, she would head straight home and that some rest should be taken to be in proper condition for the big evening. A few more words were exchanged — tender, brief — and the call ended with the promise of arriving in time to get ready for the ball. (137)

When the clock had just passed the solar weight of noon — by only a few minutes. (138)

The rhythm of knocks at the door brought alarm, footsteps quickening to open it, with a trace of apprehension. (139)

“Mr. Gustavo Almeida, if—” (140)

“Yes, this is the place!” Interrupted abruptly by a man who appeared middle-aged; before the sentence could be completed, the uniform had already been recognized. (141)

“Can you receive—” (142)

“Yes! I’m his daughter!” The impatience of youth speaking faster. (143)

“Here’s a package for him.” (144)

“Thank you very much.” (145)

“You’re welcome, miss.” (146)

“Hmph! Kids these days.” Spoken from a short distance away. (147)

The door was closed, the package placed on the table, still sealed, the headphones returned to their place — and the whole world went mute before the music. (148)

In a synchronization almost rehearsed, the mother entered right after, quietly placing a hand on the shoulders. (149)

“I didn’t see you come in — you scared me!” (150)

“You walk around with that thing shoved in your ears. What did you expect?” (151)

The girl fell silent, her face shifting into an expression that clearly revealed incomprehension and disdain. (152)

“Where’s your father?” (153)

“He’s upstairs sleeping.” (154)

“Ever since that call he made to me? It’s almost time for us to leave for the ball.” (155)

“I don’t know if it was before or after. What I do know is that he left and came back some time later.” (156)

“Left? Went where?” (157)

“He didn’t say. Just mentioned he was heading out. When he came back, he went straight upstairs and went back to sleep.” (158)

The stairs were taken slowly, steps that seemed to float between the distant noise of the house and the silence always found in that room. At the half-open door, a pause — watching him lying there, motionless, too serene for someone merely asleep. The light filtering through the narrow gap in the curtains traced along him an almost sacred outline, as if time itself preserved that stillness intact. A few short steps closer, breathing in his presence like someone returning to an old harbor. Leaning down, lips touched his face — a light kiss, almost a breath — and in that same instant a subtle shiver passed through his body, as though the tenderness of the gesture had crossed the wall of sleep and reached some inner place where she was still felt, even far from any waking hour. (159)

A shake came with a trace of unease. His eyes opened, and a smile appeared for that face so deeply admired. (160)

“What happened?” (161)

“It’s almost time to go — the ball, remember?!” (162)

“Have you been drinking?” (163)

“Just two drinks. Nothing excessive.” (164)

“Of course!” (165)

“Don’t be mad at me. Try to understand — what can I say?” (166)

“I don’t know. Some people really have no sense of risk — driving and still drinking.” (167)

The couple prepared for the ball with the quiet solemnity of those rehearsing an ancient ritual: she adjusting her hair before the vanity, he straightening his tie with the slight hesitation of someone trying to lend the moment a touch of perfection; the bedroom carried the warm scent of freshly pressed fabric, and the house seemed wrapped in a silence of expectation. The

jacket was slipped on, a deep breath drawn, and the wardrobe door slid shut; as the mirror ran along its tracks, it returned his own image — and then the world failed. For less than a second, a tear in reality: behind him, reflected with cruel precision, his wife appeared in the same dress meant for the ball, but drenched in blood from nape to ankles, the strands of fabric clinging to her skin as though torn from a nightmare; the reflection pulsed, trembling, too alive. His eyes widened, the air split in his chest — and everything vanished. In her place, only the ordinary reflection remained: a woman smiling, intact, adjusting her bracelet, asking naturally whether the tie was straight. He blinked twice, trying to recover his balance, and answered as best he could, keeping to himself the sudden fright, the impression that something had stared back from the other side of the glass. (168)

Noticing a faint pallor on his face, a question followed: (169)

“Is everything alright?” (170)

Silent he remained; silent he stayed. (171)

“I’m furious with you!” (172)

“What is it?” (173)

“Enough! I can’t keep this bottled up inside me anymore!” (174)

“Keep what?!” (175)

“Whatever it is you’ve been doing behind my back!” (176)

“That’s absurd. You know I would never—” (177)

“Funny — with all that conviction, I’m the only one who doesn’t buy it! I always knew. Always. I only kept quiet because something bigger was meant to happen today, and I wasn’t going to let everything collapse because of your — borrowed courage!” (178)

“You’re twisting everything! You’re hearing only what you want to hear!” (179)

“I’m tired! Tired of you thinking you lie so well!” (180)

“You know that from the very first moment I saw you, what I feel for you has been firm as rock.” (181)

A hesitation to argue back; posture recomposed, words left unspoken: “Bastard. In someone else’s arms, indulging himself; they’re all the same — he must say the same thing to the other one.” (182)

“You were seen — I mean, your car was seen leaving the motel, and someone told me. The motel right next to the hospital where I work. On a Sunday. Where was your head?” (183)

“Here, call my boss. She’s the one who called me to pick her up at the motel — and yes, I found it strange too. On a Sunday.” (184)

“What kind of filthy fetish is that? Isn’t there enough of that at home?” (185)

“It’s not my fault!” (186)

“You’re already inventing another story. I remember you telling me you came home agitated because of a trip.” (187)

“Yes! And I wasn’t lying. I did make a trip — I just didn’t know where I was going. I received the coordinates on my phone; I didn’t even notice. When I realized, I was inside the motel. How was I supposed to explain that to you, with your constant rush?” (188)

“You shouldn’t have gone in!” (189)

“I already did!” (190)

“What did you do?” (191)

“If I hadn’t, I would’ve been fired on the spot. I lost my nerve for a moment, but it doesn’t matter — I resigned.” (192)

A faint creak of the door came with an unsettling exclamation — (193)-

“Are you fighting?!” Interrupted by the impatient voice of the daughter. (194)

“Of course not, my daughter. Just a brief flare of tempers between us.” (195)

With the instinct to cut through the tension taking shape: (196)

“There’s a package on the table. It was delivered for you, Dad.” (197)

“Yes, thank you for reminding me, my daughter.” (198)

“Alright, Dad. There’s just one more thing I want to tell you: even when I’m a little sharp, I’ve never stopped loving you — and I never will.” Spoken with such emotion that he felt touched, sheltered by an almost angelic tenderness. (199)

“Oh, my love, I do too.” (200)

Right after those words, she threw herself into her father's arms, like someone reclaiming a long-awaited presence; then moved toward her mother, driven by the same impulse for comfort that seemed to run through the entire house. (201)

The conversation resumed, tempers less inflamed: (202)

"Let's leave the past where it belongs — behind us, please. I know you have reasons to doubt; you're tired, but I'm only asking for a moment of your attention." (203)

Consent came without strength to argue. Collapse felt near, helpless before everything that had unfolded. (204)

"It's the medical school graduation ball. You know I can't miss it." (205)

"Alright. We'll talk when you're calmer." (206)

The couple got into the car and left the parking lot without any urgency, engines and headlights gliding as though the world were slightly out of focus; at the wheel, a distant smile slipped free — the kind that seems to rise from a place where memory stumbles — when, in an abrupt jolt, the car braked hard to avoid something crossing ahead, splitting the silence for a brief second. A breath was recovered, and the dragging tone returned — nearly inert from the haze excitement had left in the voice — saying that the city always reminded him of his own, words slipping out of alignment with the moment: "You are more beloved than my own wife." She turned her face just enough to follow him with her eyes, unsettled by the lack of sense, murmuring that attention should remain on the road; the reply came — still drifting in that same slow unraveling of speech — that it must have been only the shock of the sudden brake, "things that appear without asking," it continued, while the car moved forward between highways, thoughts, and everything that had yet to be spoken — as though traveling through a fold in time. (207)

"What's that supposed to mean — 'more beloved than my wife'? Am I no longer your wife?" (208)

"Of course you are! I meant you are deeply loved; it must have been memory playing tricks on me after what just happened." (209)

"Yes! I know — just two drinks, that's the explanation." Spoken ironically. (210)

"My love, we're almost there; let's not ruin the mood — you look stunning." (211)

The car glided into the illuminated parking lot, and when the doors opened, there was a brief — almost imperceptible — instant in which the atmosphere seemed to change texture,

as though a veil had been lifted from the world. Stepping out, they walked side by side, fingers intertwined, with that rare kind of harmony that exists only when two realities touch without noticing. The lights from the hall reflected against the asphalt, washing the approaching faces in gold; and as they crossed the entrance, there lingered a sensation — sweet for one, vertiginous for the other — that they had passed through that threshold before, though no memory existed to justify such familiarity. (212)

“Well, here we are.” Said with a discreet smile. (213)

In the golden hall, where chandeliers poured light in cascading streams and crystal seemed to breathe in rhythm with the orchestra, they moved across the floor like two people who had been dancing within each other long before learning any steps. Her dress — fluid, almost liquid fabric — followed each turn, kindling small auroras along its edges, while his suit shaped the assured posture of someone who recognizes himself in the gaze of the woman he loves. The scent of jasmine mingled with the violins, and when the opening melody began — the one she had always called their song — her smile unfolded with the softness of a slow dawn, the kind no one dares to interrupt. Guests watched, but nothing intruded: between them existed a private world, silent, perfect, where steps ceased to be steps and became promises; where touch outweighed any word; where dancing together was a form of prayer. And as they turned beneath the hall’s star-lit ceiling, happiness settled upon them like light upon skin — a simple, ancient certainty that they would remain side by side for as long as time allowed. (214)

And within the entwined steps of destiny’s Möbius dance, the wind whispered like words not spoken by the body, yet spoken through it. (215)

“What an extraordinary woman you are... so beautiful, so sensual, offering me one of the most remarkable nights of my life. Your company feels like the touch of forbidden angels, and I desire you eternally. Tonight you shone like a dancing angel. I understand your strength and your delicate touch, but — today, tomorrow, or at any time — I will be your guide, leading you toward your destiny. As I always will be, my love.” (216)

Spoken for the night, for the day, for what was yet to come and for what had already passed. (217)

The music ended as though slowly gathering a veil back into itself, and the hall seemed to loosen its shoulders after so many emotions set in motion. The lights softened, revealing tired faces, lingering smiles, the shimmer of champagne in forgotten glasses. Gradually, conversations resumed in small circles — a compliment exchanged here, a hurried embrace there — while waiters moved between still-crowded tables, collecting remnants of a celebration

that seemed reluctant to end. One by one, the graduates shed their ceremonial poses, tucking diplomas beneath their arms like newly entrusted promises. The décor lost its initial splendor, and the hall began that quiet dismantling that happens only after a celebration has fulfilled its purpose. Among them, they were among the first to rise, drifting out of the still-warm atmosphere shaped by the final chords, leaving behind the mingled haze of perfume, glitter, and farewells — as though the night, for them, required another kind of continuation. (218)

“My love, I have a surprise for you.” (219)

“What kind of surprise?” (220)

“It’s been sitting on our table at home for a while. I know these past days haven’t been easy for you — that you’ve been hurt, shaken — maybe you didn’t even notice.” Spoken with a slow shake of the head. (221)

“I’m eager to reach our destination. I hope you’ll dance on me just the way you already did.” (222)

“Unfortunately, I’ll have to deny you that. Not tonight!” (223)

“What did you go there for?” (224)

“I’ll say it again — I only went to pick her up where I told you. Please, believe me.” (225)

“It’s not fair. I can’t just ignore it.” (226)

“What’s not fair is being held responsible for someone else’s irresponsibility!” (227)

“Still angry with me?” (228)

“What do you think?!” (229)

They left the hall still wrapped in music that seemed unwilling to release their bodies, walking slowly through the golden light spilling from the main doors; he, smiling a little too loosely, moved with that moist brightness in the eyes of someone who drank more than admitted, and she, holding his hand with discreet firmness, sensed the faint sway in his steps — almost imperceptible to anyone else, yet unmistakable to one who knows the weight and rhythm of the beloved — and though their laughter echoed through the parking lot, there was in her posture a growing tension, a quick glance at the key between his fingers, another at the car waiting in the dimness, then at the sky, as if silently measuring the distance between the joy of that night and the unpredictable risk that can fit within a single step too many. (230)

“Come on, doctor, pick up the pace! I’m your private driver.” Spoken with irony. (231)

“Stop being cute. Give me the car keys.” (232)

“F-for... what?... that? I’m... fine. Want me to... walk a straight line?” (233)

“I’m not joking. You can’t even form a full sentence!” (234)

“Look at me! I would never put you in any embarrassing or dangerous situation like you’re implying!” (235)

“Implying?! I’m stating it! Give me that key! I’m driving!” (236)

“You don’t trust me to drive anymore?” (237)

“Lately everything I do seems to displease you. I don’t know what else I can possibly do. I ask you for the car key and you—” (238)

“Absolutely not. I already told you — either you take public transport or I drive you.” Cut off harshly. (239)

“It’s Sunday. Public transport takes forever!” (240)

“Don’t shout at me. It’s not my problem. You see disaster in everything — then let it be that way.” (241)

“I demand your respect. Is that any way to speak? Watch yourself!” (242)

“I’m drunk and you don’t even have a license — so what now?!” (243)

“I’d like to know how long these little jokes of yours are going to continue.” (244)

“Come on, let’s take this road. Sit beside me.” (245)

“I won’t tolerate this disrespect. Let it be the last time.” Reprimanded in a firm, merciless tone. (246)

The door opened, and the passenger seat was taken, as if entering only because no other path remained. (247)

“I’ll find you a better seat. This one doesn’t seem comfortable enough for the Doctor.” (248)

The car was already on the highway when the old argument tried to resurface through her voice: (249)

“You’ve never been this much of a coward before — at a motel near my workplace?”
(250)

“Stop! We’re not going to argue about this anymore — at least not now.” (251)

He lowered his head for a brief moment, trying to locate, in the darkness that filled the interior, the radio dial. Even slightly unsteady from the alcohol, he managed to turn it on; the music that began to play muffled the engine’s hum and the weighted silence that lingered between them. It sounded like an inexplicable coincidence — unwanted and yet strangely fitting — and, for a fleeting instant, everything softened into calm, with nostalgia brushing gently against their hearts. (252)

... Now I feel as if I'm floating away
I can't feel all the pressure
And I like it this way
But my body's callin'
My body's callin'
Won't ya come back to this
World again... (253)

“You used to listen to this song all the time.” (254)

“My God! Lord Jesus!” (255)

“Watch out for the car—” (256)

Suddenly, the sound was swallowed by the violent screech of tires — two cars running side by side, one tearing into an overtake while both slammed the brakes at the same instant, unleashing a roar that seemed to stretch for miles, harsh as sharpened claws raking the asphalt and ripping through the stillness of the night. (257)

“Hold the wheel tight! Careful!” (258)

The car lost control, skidding sideways, and the world slipped into slow motion — headlights stretched into liquid blades, the hood jolted upward with a metallic gasp, the windshield burst into hundreds of shards that hovered in the air like suspended ice, each fragment catching the yellow glow of the highway lamps, gentle and lethal upon the asphalt. The sound of the impact did not arrive at once; first came a dense silence, then a muffled crash that seemed to rise from beneath the earth. One of the drivers braked instinctively, untouched by the collision, feeling the seatbelt clamp against the chest, and when the gaze turned toward the other vehicle — almost a mile away — there lay the twisted mass crushed against the

guardrail: gray smoke rising, doors pinned shut, metal folded like paper — and, amid the wreckage, a figure crawling out, slow, stubborn, dragging forward with the strength of someone who refuses to die. (259)

The vehicle that had remained intact stood motionless for a few brief minutes, until new headlights appeared on the horizon. Then it accelerated abruptly — tires burning against the asphalt, scattering fragments into the wind — in a sudden, almost instinctive escape, impossible to decipher. (260)

Indefinite minutes slowly unspooled between one act and the next. (261)

Eyes that had remained alert, braced against the world, caught — at the edge of vision — the outline of two headlights approaching the scene: first a slash of light, then the full shape of a vehicle gliding to a stop nearby. There was a subtle shift in posture, almost instinctive, from the one who watched — the gesture of someone who sensed, without needing certainty, that this moment could mean rescue, or danger, or merely destiny moving a few inches forward. Time seemed to pause before resuming its natural course. (262)

The key turned and the engine's heavy silence dissolved at once, as though the outside world had forced its way into the moment without permission. Mixed sounds — footsteps, voices, scattered noise from a place that never truly sleeps — crossed the air with the urgency of those witnessing something critical. Thoughts, still unsettled, settled against the windshield, blurring the outlines of things as if everything were slightly out of focus. Inside, two bodies remained motionless for an instant that seemed reluctant to end; there was in that arrival a discouragement difficult to name, a weight neither wished to confront. Then the hand that reached for the handle did not hesitate: the door opened with a certain haste, too quick to be casual — whether from fear of being seen or questioned. The opening exposed a brief yet striking moment, the kind time preserves even when memory tries to purge it. After that, everything moved forward, as though there were no choice but to continue. (263)

Before even crossing the entrance, a glowing sign imposed itself like fate: “emergency & urgent care.” (264)

“She’s covered in blood...” (265)

“Calm down!” (266)

“We need to help — come on!” (267)

“Make sure they provide proper care. Don’t worry. Let’s go! Quickly — we need to act now!” (268)

“Take the patient to stabilization...” (269)

“Ahh! What happened... it hurts... my arm...” (270)

“Try to stay awake — you have a head injury...” (271)

“My God... how awful. And some people still complain about life.” (272)

“It’s alright, they’re helping already.” (273)

Noticing the unrest in the expression and the approach of a police officer crossing the courtyard toward the vehicle, the figure quickly returned to the driver’s seat — too late to avoid the unwanted presence. Light knocks echoed against the window; it was the officer, the gesture clearly asking for the window to be lowered. (274)

“You know you can’t park here, right?!” Spoken while pointing toward a traffic sign. (275)

“I only brought her here... I didn’t want to cause any trouble. She was on the shoulder, so I stopped. I’m leaving, alright?!” (276)

His thoughts tangled into a whirl difficult to name — whether from the weight of the moment or from the instinctive fear certain questions awaken in those who would rather not answer them. There was, within, a haste he tried to conceal: the urgency to distance himself from any doubt, from any interpretation that might fall upon him, fair or not. When it became clear the officer intended to prolong the exchange, the harsh screech of tires against asphalt rose as a preemptive reply. He sped off too quickly, like someone afraid of explanations he would not know how to give, vanishing into the horizon before any word could reach him. (277)

Fragmented phrases flickered like electric flashes crossing trembling synapses — cutting out and reconnecting in chaotic choreography — from a life that insisted, desperately, on remaining, layered beneath the living sound of the hospital rushing to render aid. (278)

“Control the bleeding...” (279)

The frantic rattle of gurney wheels moving at speed. (280)

“Blood pressure dropping...” (281)

“Pupils slightly...” (282)

“I need gloves, now!” (283)

Voices of anguish and urgency filling the emergency room. (284)

“Mobilize the entire—” (285)

“Look, another car is pulling in!” (286)

“Call the orderly!” (287)

Two nurses appeared on the scene, firm steps carrying urgency plainly written across their faces. Fueled by adrenaline — even if it was a familiar surge — they searched for anyone available: one announced that another patient had just arrived in critical condition and that extra hands were needed in the trauma room. The other added, breath still quickened, that the day’s routine had completely unraveled — severe cases arriving back-to-back, leaving no space for the staff to catch their breath. The call echoed through the area like an unavoidable signal, summoning every nearby professional to move before the next minute grew too heavy to bear. (288)

“Prep the OR!” (289)

“Looks like it’s going to be one of those days — no smoke breaks!” Spoken to a coworker. (290)

“Well, look who’s walking right past us — what a handsome doctor. That’s what I should be focusing on.” (291)

“Dreams are free. Reality’s right here, my friend.” (292)

“Yeah... life here isn’t easy.” Replied the colleague. (293)

Some time later, within the attentive silence of the hospital environment. (294)

Then, with more urgent steps, like someone jolting awake from a deep sleep, an attempt was made to guide them firmly toward the main entrance; upon entering the central hall, a strange sound — unbearably loud to the ears — reverberated throughout the space. It began with the heavy thud of a heartbeat; for a moment, it seemed to be one’s own. Soon, however, abstract mechanical sounds merged with that rhythm — the pulse of a cardiac monitor intertwined with scattered voices and labored breathing — until the exclamation broke through: (295)

“What is this chaos?!” Spoken almost in disbelief. (296)

Before the surrounding noise could be deciphered, hurried footsteps echoed across the floor — descending from above, as if someone had been abruptly awakened. A silhouette appeared in urgency, crossing the corridor to wrap you in a firm, nearly desperate embrace. The

gesture carried relief, shock, and a tenderness that could not immediately be explained; only the tightness of the hold spoke. The space, once dominated by noise, softened at the touch of that presence, as though saying without words: “You’re here. At last.” (297)

“Where am I... Where is he...” (298)

“I wouldn’t advise that, Doctor.” (299)

“Why not?!” (300)

“Coma.” (301)

“What coma? What are you talking about?” (302)

“You were very lucky. It could have been fatal. The impact was severe, but fortunately the injuries were limited to extensive bruising, a minor wrist fracture — which won’t affect mobility — and a deep laceration to the frontal region, which caused the initial concern. The amount of blood can be alarming, I know, but the bleeding was superficial, despite being heavy. We ran a full series of imaging tests — including an MRI — and there are no signs of swelling, internal bleeding, or neurological impairment. You’re out of danger. You can rest easy.” (303)

“I can’t believe it... this can’t be happening.” (304)

“That was a terrible accident!” (305)

“I need to see my husband.” (306)

“I’m sorry, but there isn’t much we can do...” (307)

“My God, what’s happening?!” (308)

“As I said, he’s in a coma.” (309)

“Don’t worry. I’ll take you to him — it’s more than my duty.” (310)

“I need to call home. I have to speak to my daughter.” (311)

“She’s here. We’ve already arranged for her to come.” (312)

“Who’s here? Where am I?” (313)

“Your daughter.” (314)

And without warning, struck by a sudden wave, she collapsed into her colleague’s arms, who caught her and guided her to a hospital recliner beside a stretcher in room 742. (315)

When she came to, familiar faces hovered over her — shaped by worry and tenderness — still not fully understanding what they had just witnessed. (316)

“Mom! What happened? Oh my God!” (317)

“And your arm — why is it bandaged?” (318)

“It’s nothing serious, just a mild sprain; it’s my head that still hurts.” (319)

“Obviously — from the visible blow to your forehead. You needed stitches.” (320)

“And you still say it was nothing?” (321)

“I’m lucid and fully awake.” (322)

“You should get some rest.” (323)

“I’ll try. Stay with your father.” (324)

“Dad is right here beside us.” (325)

“Unfortunately, I’m seeing him in a way I never wanted to; just keep him company.”
(326)

The sound — continuous, sharp, unexpected — tore through the room like a blade of light, halting time for a breath no one could claim as their own. In the same instant, her hand lunged forward in a primitive reflex, almost an instinct of life trying to summon another; it fell against his chest, striking with the urgency of someone refusing silence. Everything seemed to unfold in slow motion — the weight of her arm descending, breath caught in her throat, the world around her blurring as if sliding off at the edges. His body gave beneath the impact — not like someone awakening, but like someone returning from a place where time does not answer to clocks — at seven-thirty in the morning. (327)

“Mom, is everything okay?” (328)

“It was just a scare, only a scare, thank God.” Attempting to calm her. (329)

Hurried knocks at the door cut through the silence of the room. The girl heard them and went to see who was knocking, her head lowered with emotion — unsettled by her father not being at her side as she wished; he was there, sleeping, yet not living beside her as she longed. (330)

At the instant the Möbius loop turned upon itself (331)

“Is it urgent?” (332)	“What is that infernal noise?” (338)
“I’m just still a little disoriented.” (333)	“It feels like no one hears me when I
“What happened?” The nurse asked.	speak — can’t you hear what I’m
(334)	saying?!” The reply lingered in the air.
	(339)
“I’m fine — I just had a bad feeling.”	
(335)	“Am I stepping into hell?!” The murmur
	continued, as if addressed to no one.
“I’m calm now.” (336)	(340)
“What bad feeling?” No answer	
followed. (337)	“Where is your mother?” (341)

“Did you hear that?!” The voice came startled. (342)

“Yes, I heard you clearly.” (343)

“No — not me. As if there were someone else speaking besides us.” (344)

“For God’s sake! Are you hearing voices now?” (345)

“Never mind. It must’ve just been my imagination, given the situation.” (346)

A little further on, when the next moment finally announced itself... (347)

“It’s that Guns N’ Roses song you loved so much, Dad.” (348)

“I wish you could hear me; we need you. You have to rise again... please, get up.” (349)

“Turn that down, my daughter!” (350)

“This can’t be happening.” The thought slipped out while the device was turned off. (351)

“Oh, great! At this rate they’ll lock me in a cage — I can’t do anything!” (352)

“Daughter, either it’s that heavy rock—” (353)

“See how you all treat me?!” (354)

“I know you seem to like nothing but chaos!” (355)

“Indifferent to my presence, as always — he’ll never come out of that coma.” The words came in the heat of the music and the familiar sense of distance, even when he was awake. (356)

“God forbid such a dark hour!” (357)

“I’ll turn it down... he seems indifferent to everything; not even music reaches him anymore.” The voice carried a quiet weariness, almost condemning the father’s presence — so near, yet so far. (358)

“I’m sorry for yelling at you, my daughter; my head’s been racing, and I understand what you’re going through.” (359)

“I’m always the one who has to understand. I just wanted to escape this loneliness for a while.” (360)

“I know, my daughter. I’m just not up to that right now, please.” (361)

When the moment — still warm — was torn open by a summons that asked no permission. (362)

“You need to go home and rest, Doctor; I’m prescribing a sedative. Go home and lie down for a while.” (363)

“But I have—” (364)

“I’m not speaking as your colleague, but as your physician. No ‘but.’ You fainted in my arms.” (365)

“I’ll call an Uber, don’t worry.” (366)

“Then go, rest and recover; everything will be fine.” (367)

“Thank you, but I don’t need medication.” (368)

“Listen to me — as a doctor yourself, take the sedatives.” (369)

“I understand. I know.” (370)

“It’s my duty as a physician to help.” (371)

“Stay here, my daughter!” (372)

“I will. I’ll pull myself together, take a shower, clear my head.” (373)

“See you soon, Mom.” The voice trembled amid the confusion. (374)

“I’m going home.” (375)

A sigh was heard — deep, forceful — as if carried from some forewarning beyond. It made her tear the headphones from her ears and look up in unease, as though touched by something spectral, turning her face toward whoever had just reached for her. (376)

“Are you trying to scare me to death?!” (377)

“I’m sorry for startling you.” (378)

“Good grief! Didn’t you just leave?!” (379)

“I forgot my wallet; could you hand it to me? The one right there beside you, please.” (380)

“Try speaking to him; he always listened to you. Even in the state he’s in now, it’s possible he can still hear you.” (381)

“I try to gather the courage to talk to him, but he’s so different.” (382)

“How is your father?” (383)

“You’re asking me that? Didn’t you hear?” (384)

“I did. That’s why I’m asking — so you’ll reflect. What I see is that there’s life in him, as there is in you; only death has no remedy — everything else can be mended.” (385)

“Call if anything happens, please.” (386)

“Now I really am leaving. A kiss.” (387)

“Another. Drive carefully. God be with you.” (388)

“As I said, I’m not driving; I’ll call an Uber or a taxi.” (389)

The car traced the winding curve into the familiar stretch of the street that led home. The engine breathed out, slow and weary, before falling silent at the gate. The sky seemed undecided between night and day, and the cold wind carried the scent of earth, of

dawn, of something interrupted. For a moment, everything stood still — the shuttered windows, the yard still glazed with dew, the door heavy with too many memories. Then the car door opened slowly, and a figure stepped out, hesitant, with steps that betrayed neither guilt nor exhaustion nor simply too much truth for that hour. It lingered there, motionless before its own shadow, breathing the kind of air that belongs only to beginnings one does not wish for. And, as if releasing a sentence that refused to die, murmured to the rising day: (390)

— “Bitter home, home...” (391)

Meanwhile, in the couple’s house: (392)

A phone already gripped in trembling hands and thick, confused thoughts waited only a second before dialing — that second in which silence seems to measure fate. On the other side, when the screen lit up, the brief vibration traveled across the table like an intimate warning, almost premonitory. The number displayed brought neither comfort nor threat — only immediate recognition, the kind that awakens relief and vertigo at once. The ringing persisted, filling the space with a tightening sensation, and both worlds — the one calling and the one answering — seemed to converge within the same suspended breath. A finger slid to accept the call. (393)

“Hello.” (394)

“Who is this?” (395)

“You’re disgusting!” (396)

“Excuse me? Who do you think you’re talking to?!” (397)

“To a woman who opens herself to any man.” (398)

“What happened, my dear?!” (399)

“Don’t you dare throw baseless accusations at me. Who do you think you are?”
(400)

“Pathetic!” (401)

“Why are you insulting me like this? I don’t have to stand here listening to this—
” (402)

“But I’m the one being cheated on, aren’t I?!” The interruption came in a shout.
(403)

“Now I see the number you called from. My apologies — I wasn’t paying attention. I know exactly who this is. Mrs.— I mean, Doctor.” (403-2)

“Did you think I was your lover?!” (404)

“My lover? My— whatever! Mr. Gustavo Almeida, let this be clear to everyone, is only my driver.” (405)

“Particularly personal, very close.” (406)

“Stop with the insinuations.” (407)

“That was never my type.” (408)

“I don’t understand.” (409)

“I’m married.” (500)

“And since when is that an obstacle?” (501)

“For people without scruples, it isn’t. But before you go any further, let me be direct: I’m a lesbian. I’m married to a woman.” (502)

“I... I’m sorry. I didn’t know.” A brief pause followed, restrained and embarrassed. (503)

“It’s fine. That doesn’t affect me anymore.” (504)

“I’m completely shaken — physically and emotionally.” (505)

“I can explain in person, if you’d like.” (506)

The call ended. (507)

Upon ending the call so abruptly, the thoughts seemed to settle for a few minutes — not out of complete relief, nor from any firm conviction, but from that strange sensation that follows decisive moments, when the body insists on drawing a deep breath before understanding what it has just done. The phone remained in the hand a little longer, heavy as if holding the shadow of a choice not yet fully measured. There was an almost-relief — the kind that eases only the surface of the chest — and beneath it, a rough

uncertainty, vibrating like something still without form. When the device was finally lowered, the quiet around seemed to widen — not calm, merely quiet — and stillness lingered, as though some fine and decisive thread within destiny itself had shifted. (508)

In the brief interval granted by time, there was the silent gesture of forgiveness — unspoken, merely intuited — and with it, hope, timid yet persistent, knocking as though rediscovering passage through ruins. The moment gathered doubts, anguish, the weight of what had not yet been named, and even so, carried the body forward — inevitably — toward the destiny that waited with its own shadows and light. It was necessary to move on: not from weakness, but from the intimate demand to face again what had scattered, to allow silence to stitch what had once been torn. (509)

“Yes, I will. I fought hard not to show up on my first day of work, no matter how shaken I may be.” The words were spoken aloud, as if to convince oneself that moving forward was necessary. (510)

She crossed the hospital entrance with a step that tried to be steady, though exhaustion pulsed through her bones. The receptionist noticed at once and, in a subdued tone, explained that her official first day had begun under unusual circumstances: during the night, two cars had arrived, each carrying a different victim, and only one had been declared dead — the receptionist, newly on shift, did not know which; shortly afterward, an ambulance had brought in more injured from the same accident. And at that very moment, she added, the patient in room 742 had been rushed to the ICU after going into cardiac arrest; the team was attempting resuscitation behind closed doors and faltering vital signs. The news struck like sudden weight: color drained from the face, the legs nearly gave way for a second, as if the floor itself had shifted, cutting short the inner monologue. (511)

“Please, Lord... help me find the strength.” (512)

The receptionist leaned over the counter, asking if everything was alright, but the question dissolved into air — the distance had already been broken, stairs taken in haste, the call rising behind: “Doctor! Doctor, wait!”; and still the movement continued without looking back, driven by a pressing impulse that adrenaline carried forward with unconscious force, toward the stabilization wing. (513)

“Well... what’s going on with her?” A colleague asked. (514)

“Newbie nerves. Relax.” (515)

At the ICU door: (516)

“I’m here to assist the team.” (517)

“We already have sufficient staff providing the highest level of care possible, and unfortunately, I must decline. I’m noticing signs of emotional instability.” (518)

“I am ready — emotionally steady — to fulfill my duty!” (519)

“You are raising your voice without realizing it.” (520)

“Why now?” (521)

“With sincere professional counsel, and in accordance with the Medical Code of Ethics — which you know well — I ask for your understanding. I can allow, and recommend, that you observe through the glass. Be assured that everything possible is being done.” (522)

“I’ll stay here.” (523)

“I understand. It’s alright.” (524)

“Thank you. May God bless your hands.” (525)

“Of course, Doctor. I completely understand.” (526)

Through the narrow ICU window, time seemed to fold inward in silent layers, as though two realities brushed against each other without recognition. Inside, the staff moved with near-choreographed precision: gloves striking metal trays, monitors blinking like nervous stars, syringes passing between steady hands, and the gurney at the center — the axis of chaos — where a body struggled to remain. Each chest compression sent faint tremors through the glass, as if matter itself acknowledged the urgency. Commands shifted in short, tense exchanges, and the defibrillator rose like swallowed thunder. A forehead pressed against the cold pane, breath held halfway, as though mere presence might interfere. The reflection staring back revealed a face drained hollow, suspended between disbelief and mute pain. When the monitor wavered into a jagged line, damp hands slid down the glass, dragging from it a low, vibrating sound — half friction, half lament — as though the surface recognized the weight being carried; and in that instant, a colleague’s earlier words settled with terrible clarity, and a thought cut through like a

blade: time was no longer an accident... it was a sentence. The first to step out of the emergency room was a physician who, noticing the expression of her colleague, approached. (527)

“Doctor, do you need assistance? Are you feeling unwell?” (528)

“Doctor?!” The question came firmer, receiving no response. (529)

“Jesus! The Doctor has fainted!” (530)

Returning to awareness, the moment the eyes opened, there was a physician at the side who — now fully in professional capacity rather than merely as a colleague — began to guide with steady care. (531)

“No... this can’t be happening.” (532)

“I’m so sorry, Doctor, for what you’ve just witnessed. You understand what I’m trying to say — even with our routine, we can’t detach from the weight of it. We don’t always manage to. And the hardest part is speaking... to a family member. My condolences.” (533)

“God... why?” (534)

“I insist you take the sedatives I prescribed. You may feel strong right now, but it’s afterward that the impact settles in.” (535)

“Daughter!” (536)

The word escaped before it could be restrained — fragile, fractured. “Mom...” Nothing else followed. The rest collapsed into sudden, wet, disordered sobs, as though all the accumulated fear had finally found a fissure through which to spill. (537)

“Easy, my daughter. Come here — give me a hug. I’m strong enough to warm myself with your affection. Don’t be like this.” (538)

“Alright, Mom...” (539)

She nodded with difficulty, her voice undone by sobs. Tears kept breaking her breath, turning each word into effort. Even so, she moved toward her mother, guided by an instinctive need to anchor herself. (540)

“I’d better go.” (541)

They did not linger. They gathered their belongings and left the room empty — a room they had once imagined would always remain theirs — now shadowed by the knowledge that soon other bodies would lie there, seeking healing, yearning for the unguarded embrace of a love they themselves had once felt pulse within those four walls. (542)

The way home felt longer than usual, like a road without end, until at last they reached their residence. Two mute souls clothed in bodies and nothing more entered with steps that seemed detached from their own weight, as though the door had opened inward into a silence too vast to measure. The air inside stood still — heavy, saturated with something unnamed on the first night: shock, exhaustion, disbelief. The lights seemed whiter than they should have been, the furniture more immobile, as if everything watched without offering refuge. One presence let a coat fall onto the first chair encountered; the other remained standing, unmoving, steadying breath. There was that subtle tremor born when the world insists on continuing while everything else has stopped. Nothing was said. Eyes, glassed or emptied, searched for something to rest upon — a wall, a corner, the outline of absence itself. The house, which had once sheltered routine, now received an unnamable weight: returning after something that does not dissolve upon crossing a threshold. They remained beneath that roof which, however familiar, felt incapable of containing what still vibrated within them. Not a word was exchanged. No bath was sought, no comfort, no explanation — only the ascent of stairs as though carrying a silent excess, each step heavier than the last. Upstairs, they sensed no other wakeful presence; the entire house lay armored in grief. Clothes were removed in slow, nearly automatic gestures, and they surrendered to what rest was possible — a succession of restless thoughts biting inward without granting themselves a name. They slept as one yields — not by choice, but because the mind, saturated, could no longer endure another involuntary alarm. (543)

“Home, sweet home...” The words slipped out involuntarily, as though fleeing the impact of external reality. (544)

Day of the funeral — repeated across the footers of headlines, an omen folded twice in time, imposed tragedy — necessary life — along the narrow luminous band of Möbius. (545)

They descended the steps slowly, side by side, as though still trying to recover their axis after a night that had left its marks. The mother rested her hand on the railing — the gesture steady, but not secure; something in her was fractured — invisible to a distracted eye, unmistakable to her daughter's. The young woman matched her pace with restrained attentiveness, almost protective, masking her own exhaustion behind a posture too erect for someone so drained. The silence between them was not hostile, but dense — filled with thoughts neither dared to disturb. Light from somewhere ahead stretched their shadows long across the floor, and for a moment the mother hesitated, as if the ground were still uncertain beneath her. A dry, contained sigh escaped her, and the daughter, without speaking, simply adjusted her rhythm to remain beside her. It was clear they needed that brief pause — even without words, even without comfort. When they reached the ground level, they continued in slightly different directions, each carrying a private unrest, yet bound by the complicity of shared sensation. (546)

“And exclusively from the local cemetery of our small town, we are here broadcasting live the funeral of the tragic accident that occurred near the site where yesterday the medical school graduation ball was held. We note a profound grief among those just arriving — a case that deeply shook our community. The burial is taking place late this afternoon; the sky hangs heavy with dense clouds beneath an overcast that has not yet broken, though to those present it seems perpetually on the verge. The ceremony will proceed without interruption; we will allow the scene itself to reveal the weight of images that already speak for themselves.” The camera reveals that only a few have attended, maintaining a respectful distance around the place of eternal rest. The officiant raises a firm, measured voice, beginning: “The Lord is our shepherd, we shall not want; even though we walk through the valley of the shadow of death...” (547)

Suddenly, as though the climate itself had been summoned by an unseen force, a strong wind rose — unexpected, displaced, almost improper for that region. The garments of those exposed to it shuddered like living creatures, and for a moment the world seemed to hold its breath. The whisper of the wind carried something neither requested nor understood: a subtle vibration that made the treetops tremble, skin bristle, and the eyes of the mourners lift as if sensing an arrival. It was not a breeze, not a mere current of air — it was one of those small fractures in reality that warn without language, that mark without explanation. A calling. An announcement. An invisible hand brushing

the nape of the living, murmuring that certain presences cross through time before the news exists, before the hidden is revealed, before grief finds its name. (548)

The world fell abruptly silent, and those gathered stood motionless for a few suspended seconds. (549)

“...You anoint our heads with oil and our cups overflow; goodness and mercy shall surely follow us, and we shall dwell in the house of the Lord forever.” The “amen” rose like a single woven voice from those witnessing. And thus the ceremony was concluded: “from dust we came, and to dust we shall return; may God console the families.” Laments began — sobs broken by gasps and murmured words swallowed by grief — as the descent into the seven feet below commenced slowly, marked by the hollow sound of earth striking the depths of the grave. Some lowered their heads in a gesture almost involuntary, as though struck by a belated understanding — something between reverence and vertigo. In the end, no one hurried to leave; they merely stepped back in hesitant dispersal, carrying with them a dense silence that clung to the skin long after the ritual had ended. The news crew moved in. (550)

“Let’s try to speak with a family member who appears to be stepping away from the burial site and moving closer to us — Sir, would you care to say a few words?” “No comment. Please respect the grief of those present.” “Ma’am! Ma’am, perhaps you could—” A hand suddenly rose, covering the camera lens entirely. (551)

“Bunch of jerks — people want to see the news!” she snapped indignantly, switching off the device. (552)

“Here everything turns into an interview. News spreads faster than the wind.” (553)

“It’s not what I want.” (554)

“I know. And I can see how fragile you are right now.” (555)

“I’ll get a doctor’s note at the hospital!” (556)

“Please, don’t insist. I’m going to work.” (557)

“I understand, Doctor. But you know you can request a medical leave note.” (558)

“Let’s talk about it later.” (559)

“We need to leave here. Now.” (560)

“Easy... take the keys; you’re clearly in better condition to drive.” (561)

There was no need to fully extend a hand — the keys were almost snatched away.
(562)

“I’m glad you’re here with us.” (563)

And so, with that reluctant consent, they set out along the road back home. (564)

When life — or something resembling it — began to assert itself again... (565)

The package still rested on the table where it had remained since delivery; it was picked up, and the path led toward the backyard, to sit near the garden that encircled the house in a wall of flowers and ornamental plants — a place fit either to immortalize, or finally bury, that moment of love: singular, final, or beginning? The thought arose along the intended course. (566)

The parcel was opened as though touching a reliquary fashioned from faint glimmers, and as the wrapping drew back, the restrained brilliance slipped between waiting fingers as if it had waited a lifetime for that narrow tear of light. The case settled into the palm with the precise weight of things that alter destinies; when the lid yielded, the air itself seemed to hold, and two rings — twins in form, distinct in reflection — emerged against the dark velvet, radiating a serene, warm gold capable of piercing even the most wounded gaze. The metal captured the clarity of the afternoon and returned a glow so gentle that the face before it brightened without effort, as though the shine recognized its bearer before the eyes could fully comprehend it. There was promise there, and farewell, and return; there was everything two lives may carry when they finally converge. (567)

“I remember — even now — how I always wished for a wedding ring, and what I would hear in reply was: ‘The bands of our love are our hearts.’ I used to think it was a way of mocking romance, and I would always smile.” (568)

The rings rested in the palm, shining with a simplicity that seemed older than themselves — a gold modest, yet resolute, fashioned to endure bright days and devastated ones alike. They were contemplated in silence, the gaze lowering as though afraid to touch

a fragile mirror. Then, with a restrained movement — almost hesitant — one was taken and slipped onto the ring finger, a brief gesture carrying the weight of entire years. The head remained bowed, and the first tears broke quietly, tracing the face like lines of light across wet stone. Nothing was spoken — yet, forgiveness, uneven and trembling, began to emerge there, in the space between times, gentle enough not to demand, strong enough to reach even the unseen soul that might dwell within that garden. The rest of the day dissolved into a rare stillness, a small but complete peace, as though for a few hours everything had returned to its proper rails. (569)

And then time, in its quiet caprice, opened a fracture there and divided the moment in two... (570)

“I forgive you.” (571)

Ne me quitte pas

Il faut oublier, tout peut s'oublier

Qui s'enfuit déjà

Oublier le temps des malentendus et

Le temps perdu

À savoir comment

Oublier ces heures qui tuaient parfois

À coups de pourquoi

Maysa - Ne me quitte pas (572)

“For what I am not guilty?” No answer came, as though the words had not been heard — and there was no insistence, for something inside already felt displaced. (573)

“It is I who ask your forgiveness.”

Again, no reply — yet there was comfort in what had been spoken. (574)

For a second, the head remained lowered, as though clinging to each word in a long-awaited embrace; there was only time to utter a single phrase: (575)

“Our song — what a coincid—” (576)

For a fleeting instant, something insinuated itself — not as sound, but as an unseen touch. (577)

A brief anguish crossed the chest, fine and precise, like the lost echo of another's thought finding rest in a body that should not have heard it. It was a silent impact, the kind that leaves no mark yet shifts something inward, compelling the soul to turn toward a direction it cannot name. (578)

“Yes! Everything is alright — all is at peace, my love!” (579)

The new is born / The old contemplates: (580)

END

Bruno Salgado – 12/12/2025